

Do the Right Thing (Teacher Version)

Corresponding Material

Digital Citizenship and Cyber Hygiene: Cyberbullying

Discussion

The internet has provided tremendous value. It provides a potential for learning, socializing, and leisure. However, with these advancements, also comes new problems, including cyberbullying. Cyberbullying is the use of electronic communication to bully a person, typically by sending messages of an intimidating or threatening nature. It is the most common online risk for teenagers and can occur to any young person online. Unlike bullying, there are no common risk factors. It really can happen to anyone.

What to do if you encounter cyberbullying:

- Tell a trusted adult (i.e. a parent or a teacher)
- Contact host/website providers if inappropriate material is being posted on their website.
- Save all evidence if bullying is taking place online.
- Do not respond to rude messages. This only encourages the bully.
- If the cyberbullying is directed at another person, stand up for the victim!

Further Discussion

This activity is intended to cause students to reflect on different cyberbullying situations and how they would personally react. Before reading the case studies, lead a discussion about cyberbullying using the questions below as a guide.

1. What is cyberbullying?
2. How is cyberbullying different from other forms of bullying? Why do you think some people bully others online?
3. Why do you think it is hard sometimes for someone to speak up when they are being bullied?
4. What is one thing you could do today (right now!) to help stop or prevent cyberbullying?

NOTE: Please review this activity before using it in class because some of the case studies have mature themes.

Class Exercise

Read each scenario below. For each scenario, discuss with a classmate how well you think the person in each story below handled cyberbullying and how you might have handled it differently.

Scenario 1:

Sami began receiving rude emails from an email address she did not recognize. The emails ridiculed her hairstyle and the clothes she wore to school, so she assumed that the emails were from someone she knew. Sami decided to delete the emails and not tell her parents because she did not want to lose internet privileges.

Did Sami handle the incident well? If not, how could she have handled the situation differently?

Sami did not handle this situation as well as she could have. Sami did do the right thing by not responding to the emails, however, she should have saved the emails as proof of the incident. Also, Sami should have immediately told her parents or another trusted adult.

Scenario 2:

David received a friend request from Charlie. He had met Charlie once or twice but did not know him very well. To add to his growing number of friends, David accepted the friend request. Soon after, Charlie started posting strange photographs on David's timeline. David quickly consulted his parents who advised him to send Charlie a private message asking him to stop. When Charlie continued to post these photos on David's timeline, David "unfriended" Charlie on Facebook and blocked Charlie from seeing his Facebook account. He then reported the photographs Charlie had posted to Facebook.

Did Charlie handle the incident well? If not, how could he have handled the situation differently?

Charlie handled the incident well. He saved the emails, told a trusted adult, and also reported the photographs to Facebook administration.

Scenario 3:

Patricia Brown received an Instagram follow from Patricia Brown, a fake Instagram account aimed at making fun of Patricia. Patricia began to scroll through the photos and cry. Instantly she became enraged. She had been having an ongoing problem with Mary, a girl at school, and realized right away Mary was the one behind the fake Instagram account. To get back at Mary, Patricia made a fake Instagram named Hairy Mary and started posting photos of Mary. This only escalated the problem and both fake accounts continued to post horrible photos.

Did Patricia handle the incident well? If not, how could she have handled the situation differently?

Patricia did not handle the incident well. Patricia should have told an adult right away. She also should not have "responded" to the bully. By creating another fake Instagram account, Patricia became a bully as well which only encouraged Mary to continue.

Scenario 4:

Kyle and Mark were really great friends. They had a non-stop group chat where they texted all day long. One day, Kyle had an argument with another student in his class named Ryan. Kyle was pretty annoyed with Ryan and texted Mark mean comments about Ryan. Since Mark was good friends with Ryan, Mark chose not to respond and finally Kyle stopped making rude remarks.

Did Mark handle the incident well? If not, how could he have handled the situation differently?

Mark could have handled the situation better. While the bullying was not directed at Mark, Mark had the opportunity to stop the comments and stand up for Ryan. Though Mark did not engage with Kyle any further, he definitely could have made it known that the comments being made were not okay.